Evidence Brief #1 — Narrow claims that are stable

Status: Internal draft. Not a public practitioner mailing. Public Evidence Briefs wait until 10–12 cards are stable (catalog now: 7).

Audience if later published: clinicians, educators, and policy readers who need the *narrow* High claim, the Low overclaim, and one proportionate action.

Catalog: 68 cards; 7 stable; 61 draft. This brief covers six laboratory/prevention claims. The seventh stable card, neonatal-cardiopulmonary-transition.md, is a typical-term physiology sequence and is not restated here.

Science, Interpretation, and Art stay uncollapsed. A High finding is not a parenting protocol.

1. Periconceptional folic acid and neural-tube defects

Card: prenatal-folate-ntd.md. Grade: High for NTD risk reduction; Low for other anomalies and later cognition.

Randomized trials (MRC 1991 recurrence; Czeizel & Dudás 1992 first occurrence) and the De-Regil 2015 Cochrane synthesis (five trials; NTD RR 0.31) show that periconceptional folic acid substantially reduces neural-tube-defect-affected pregnancy. That is a structural embryonic outcome.

Does not mean: supplementation guarantees typical development; an NTD always implies parental nutritional failure; folic acid is a general brain-optimization tool.

Proportionate action: population fortification and recommended periconceptional folic acid. Supplement maximalism and cognitive-enhancement framing do not follow.

2. Infant statistical speech segmentation

Card: infant-statistical-speech-segmentation.md. Grade: High in the laboratory; Low for household transfer.

Eight-month-olds can use transitional probabilities in a brief artificial-speech stream to distinguish word-like units from part-words (Saffran, Aslin & Newport 1996; Aslin, Saffran & Newport 1998).

Does not mean: the infant already knows words; two minutes of nonsense speech is how children find words at home; statistical learning is a complete theory of grammar.

Proportionate action: ordinary talk in a shared world. Segmentation software for infants does not follow.

3. Infant contingency learning

Card: infant-contingency-learning.md. Grade: High under control; Low for transfer and adult-like cause.

In the mobile-conjugate-reinforcement paradigm, a young infant can learn that a self-generated action predicts a sensory consequence (Rovee & Rovee 1969; decades of laboratory use summarized in Cuevas 2025).

Does not mean: infants are miniature scientists; every repeated action is conscious goal pursuit; parents must run training protocols.

Proportionate action: ordinary opportunities to act and notice consequences. Intensive stimulation programs do not follow.

4. Infant social referencing under uncertainty

Card: infant-social-referencing.md. Grade: High in the laboratory; Low as an attachment verdict.

Late in the first year, infants can use a familiar adult's emotional signal to regulate approach or withdrawal in an ambiguous situation (Sorce et al. 1985; Walden & Ogan 1988).

Does not mean: stranger wariness is insecure attachment; a parent who shows fear has injured the child; look-frequency measures parental worth.

Proportionate action: ordinary presence of a trusted adult in new situations. Training parents to "perform" referencing does not follow.

5. Still-face disruption of expected social contingency

Card: infant-still-face-paradigm.md. Grade: High as a procedure effect; Low as an attachment verdict.

When a familiar adult suddenly becomes unresponsive in face-to-face interaction, infants typically protest, look away, and try to re-engage (Tronick et al. 1978; Mesman et al. 2009 meta-analysis).

Does not mean: a distressed still-face proves insecure attachment or parental failure; co-regulation is constant calm.

Proportionate action: ordinary, repairable interaction. Ranking infants by protest does not follow.

6. Infant perceptual narrowing for speech contrasts

Card: infant-perceptual-narrowing.md. Grade: High for laboratory attunement; Moderate for a universal timetable; Low as a sealed deadline.

During the first year, native-language phonetic contrasts are maintained or strengthened while sensitivity to some nonnative contrasts declines (Werker & Tees 1984; Kuhl et al. 1992). This is attunement, not deletion of a universal dictionary.

Does not mean: a rigid deadline after which a second language cannot be learned; hearing more than one language confuses the infant.

Proportionate action: ordinary participation in a linguistic community. Phonetic-discrimination training as cognitive enhancement does not follow.

How to read this brief

Each item is a *narrow* High (or High-lab) claim that cleared five promotion rules: resolvable sources; no retraction/EoC; independent conceptual replication on the card; YAML grades matching in-body grades; "What This Does Not Mean" matching the identification. Neighboring Low grades are part of the finding. They are not disclaimers pasted on afterwards.

Do not distribute this file as a practitioner product until the catalog has a larger stable set. The markdown source is the record; a two-page PDF is generated beside it for layout checks.